



Report to Congress on Evaluation of Activities from the Global Fragility Act

Section 7019(e) of the Department of State, Foreign Operations, and Related Programs Appropriations Act, 2024 (Div. F, P.L. 118-47) and House Report 118-146

Introduction

Consistent with section 7019(e) of the Department of State, Foreign Operations, and Related Programs Appropriations Act, 2024 (Div. F, P.L. 118-47) and House Report 118-146, The Department submits this report on impact frameworks, consistent with paragraph 7 of Section 506 of the Global Fragility Act (GFA) of 2019. The report summarizes the GFA Strategic Monitoring, Evaluation, and Learning (MEL) Framework first, which presents the overarching approach for generating evidence and driving learning and adaptation based on progress being made towards the successful implementation of the United States Strategy to Prevent Conflict and Promote Stability (SPCPS). The report then provides summaries of the detailed MEL plans developed for the four GFA priority countries (Haiti, Libya, Mozambique, and Papua New Guinea) and one region (Coastal West Africa, comprising Benin, Côte d'Ivoire, Ghana, Guinea, and Togo). The full Strategic MEL Framework and country/region MEL plans are attached to this report as annexes for reference.

The Strategic MEL Framework and country/region plans will be used to measure strategic interagency outcomes related to goals in the SPCPS and objectives and sub-objectives in the country/region plans. MEL of programs and activities will be used to assess the contributions of specific efforts to those outcomes. Interagency working

groups, informed by consultations with local and international partners, developed the framework and plans. Both the framework and the plans are living documents that will be iteratively adjusted to improve measurement and to reflect changing contexts, learning, and strategic adjustments.

Strategic MEL Framework

The Strategic MEL Framework presents the approach for generating evidence, defining analyses, and driving learning that will enable a strengthened understanding of progress toward the four goals in the SPCPS.

It calls for evaluations and learning activities to answer questions that are relevant across all five country/region contexts, including evaluation of the U.S. Government's implementation of SPCPS Goal 3 (Partnerships) and Goal 4 (Management). In the longer term, the framework will assess the contributions of SPCPS implementation to Goal 1 (Prevention) and Goal 2 (Stabilization), using a systemic set of indicators of sustainable peace other than the specific aspects targeted in the country/region plans. The framework also includes contextual variables to monitor general risks to successful conflict prevention and stabilization, as identified in the peacebuilding literature, including atrocity early warning indicators.

The Strategic MEL Framework is anchored by the Global Learning Agenda, which will enable evidence exchange across the interagency in Washington, Embassies and Missions, bilateral and multilateral partners, civil society, and other stakeholders. The learning agenda drives the generation of a robust evidence base about the causes of conflict and fragility and the effectiveness of interventions that will support better decision-making and adaptations under the SPCPS and beyond. The MEL framework advances each Agency's implementation of the Foundations for Evidence Based Policymaking Act, as well as furthers goals outlined in the strategies for Women, Peace, and Security and Atrocity Prevention by incorporating key concepts in the learning approach, evaluations, and indicators.

Country/Region MEL Plans

The country/region MEL plans track progress towards achieving the interagency strategic objectives and sub-objectives of the country/region 10-year plans for the joint

effects of diplomacy, foreign assistance, and security cooperation. They also monitor country-specific risks to successful implementation. Each plan draws on monitoring, evaluations, and other data sources, for periodic learning activities at embassies and posts that will generate insights into the implementation of the SPCPS Plan and inform adaptive management. The country/region MEL plans are implemented by interagency staff, in collaboration with local partners, and remain living documents responsive to ongoing learning and changes in context. Baseline assessment of the metrics in each plan are underway. The summaries below highlight key features of each plan.

Coastal West Africa (CWA)

The CWA 10-year SPCPS Plan includes three objectives: strengthening social cohesion; improving government responsiveness, inclusion, and accountability; and enhancing security force responsiveness and accountability. The CWA monitoring approach involves a structured process of reviewing media reporting, program performance reports, and cables, as well as meeting with diplomacy, development, and security force personnel to gauge the extent to which United States Government (USG) interventions have contributed to achieving the plan objectives and sub-objectives. The monitoring plan also tracks context indicators to ensure an accurate understanding of the operating environment and process indicators to understand the effectiveness of interagency and partner collaboration and adaptive management. The evaluation plan includes several periodic evaluations, beginning with a baseline assessment, that utilize both qualitative and quantitative research methods. The evaluation approach also employs an annual “alignment survey” which provides a snapshot of key stakeholders’ (USG and partners) perceptions of progress toward achieving the objectives. With a focus on relevant learning priorities, the CWA approach to learning focuses on a mix of annual convenings, involving both the USG and partners, targeted “huddles” that facilitate learning across countries and technical sectors, and knowledge management platforms and strategies. Personnel from across the CWA countries and across the interagency, in close collaboration with local partners, implement the MEL plan.

Haiti

The Haiti 10-year SPCPS Plan includes two objectives: advancing responsive governance and security; and supporting an engaged and prosperous citizenry. To

support the implementation of the SPCPS Plan, the Haiti MEL plan provides a comprehensive overview of adaptive approaches to monitoring, evaluation, and learning. The evaluation plan proposes independent and objective evaluations to inform learning and decision-making. Using fit-for-purpose methodologies, the evaluations will include rapid, highly focused research, performance, and impact evaluations, and multi-sectoral or cross-cutting evaluations. The findings of the evaluations will be used to document evidence, outcomes, and changes over time, and help verify strategic- and activity-level theories of change to support strategic planning and future activity design. To achieve the SPCPS Plan objectives, the MEL plan requires regular coordination and collaboration with partners and stakeholders to share knowledge; to learn systematically by drawing on evidence; to reflect on new evidence and context shifts; and to make adaptations as necessary. An interagency MEL Working Group implements the learning plan, which includes a set of learning priorities and questions that align with the SPCPS Plan objectives. The plan includes interagency quarterly discussions of performance data and results of evaluations, a biannual “Pause and Reflect” event, after action reviews, and collaborative USG and stakeholder consultations.

Libya

The Libya 10-year SPCPS Plan has four objectives: advancing its transition to a unified, democratically elected, stable political system; integration of the historically marginalized south; progressing towards a civilian-controlled, unified military and security apparatus; and fostering sustainable and equitable economic growth. The performance monitoring approach uses strategic quantitative indicators, milestones, and qualitative assessments to measure progress towards the objectives and sub-objectives in the Libya SPCPS Plan. The monitoring plan also includes context indicators to track changes in the operating environment and process indicators to understand the effectiveness of SPCPS implementation management, as well as collaboration efforts with the USG interagency and partners. The Libya evaluation plan consists of three strategic evaluations (baseline, midline, and endline) and learning from activity-level evaluations and other studies. The learning plan is built around five agreed-upon learning priorities, from which the interagency developed learning questions that are used to inform potential evaluation questions, frame MEL findings, and plan learning activities with the interagency and partners. A core group of representatives from the

interagency, in collaboration with the Libya External Office, the interagency Libya MEL Working Group, other USG stakeholders, and local partners, implements the MEL plan.

Mozambique

The Mozambique 10-year SPCPS Plan includes four objectives: strengthening capacity of local stakeholders; improving government accountability in justice and security sectors; strengthening the role of private sector and government in inclusive and sustainable economic growth; and enhancing local government's responsiveness to local needs. The monitoring plan includes a combination of performance, context, and process indicators, and aligns with local research efforts and priorities. Performance monitoring draws on information collected by Mozambican research organizations, including through the "Municipal Barometer" and the "Social Cohesion Barometer," and applies geospatial data systems and remote monitoring approaches in non-permissive environments. Context monitoring includes a set of targeted indicators to monitor emerging risks and opportunities that could impact the achievement of the objectives. Additionally, process monitoring includes indicators that capture information on the effectiveness of interagency and local partnerships and adaptive management. The evaluation plan describes the different types of evaluations (process and outcome evaluations) that take place at specific intervals, assessing the progress towards achieving the plan's objectives. Drawing on monitoring, evaluations, and other data sources, periodic learning activities will produce insights into the implementation of the SPCPS Plan and inform adaptive management.

Papua New Guinea (PNG)

The PNG 10-year SPCPS Plan includes three objectives: strengthen community capacity to prevent, mitigate, and respond to violence; support sustainable and equitable economic growth; and improve justice systems and professionalize security forces. The monitoring plan describes how mixed methods approaches using primary and secondary data will capture strategic-level developments. Localized and contextually relevant indicators will assess performance, context, process, and assumptions. The evaluation plan identifies four performance evaluations—one baseline, two midlines, and one endline—noting the potential for other relevant evaluations. These evaluations—written to be accessible and tailored to local

audiences—will generate new evidence that will drive learning and inform strategic decision-making. The Collaboration, Learning, and Adaptation (CLA) plan defines how periodic learning events with participation of the interagency and local PNG stakeholders will drive reflection and adaptation. The MEL plan also identifies notional key learning questions and identifies how learning will be generated, disseminated to a variety of stakeholders, and applied. The MEL plan notes that all MEL activities must be institutionally, culturally, linguistically, and geographically appropriate. Furthermore, MEL activities will occur in partnership with PNG communities and other partners.

Conclusion

Taken together, the Strategic MEL Framework and the country/region MEL plans form a multi-layered foundation of evidence that will inform learning, decision-making, and adaptation at multiple levels of SPCPS implementation. At the global level, evidence generated through execution of the Strategic MEL Framework will produce lessons across SPCPS countries, informing similar efforts elsewhere about effective approaches to conflict prevention and stabilization and forms of management and partnership that best support these efforts. At the country/region level, evidence generated through execution of country/region MEL plans will inform iterative learning and decision-making about achieving the specific kinds of conflict prevention and stabilization goals required by the SPCPS Plans in those contexts.

Several key activities are planned in the months ahead: baseline analyses will be conducted across all GFA countries; learning agenda activities will be designed; evaluations will be scoped to address the questions comprising both the global and country-level learning agendas; and processes for collecting monitoring data at both the country/region, and global levels will be established. These streams of effort will continue to build a growing evidence base for sustained learning and adaptation to inform GFA strategy, operations, and programming, as well as the USG's conflict prevention and stabilization policies and programming writ large. Simultaneously, engagement with local partners on country/region level MEL will deepen, working towards local ownership and use of the MEL to inform their own decisions as they increasingly take ownership of these SPCPS conflict prevention and stabilization efforts.